



Swype Beta for Android

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HTC Desire VC in India

HTC recently unveiled its dual sim Android smartphone, the HTC Desire VC in India which is available at ₹21,999.

MFD Test

HOW WE TESTED

We called in for MFDs under ₹15,000. We got a healthy mix of colour MFDs as well as monochrome laser MFDs. We don't think anyone at home or a SoHo setup will spend more than this on an MFD.

Our test setup was as follows:

- **Processor:** Intel Core i7-3770K @ 3.5GHz
- **RAM:** 2x4GB Kingston HyperX DDR3 RAM @ 1333 MHz
- **Motherboard:** ASRock Z77 Extreme 4
- **Power Supply:** Corsair HX620W
- **Monitor:** BenQ EW 2430V

We ran a few dry runs with the MFDs before actually starting off with our tests, so as to get the MFDs activated. We used standard A4 sized paper for normal print and copy tests, and Kodak Photo glossy paper for photo prints. The print tests were standard printer tests – quality of text printing, mixed document printing and photo printing. The text-only documents were reviewed for clarity of the smallest and largest

fonts, and we looked for evenness of the text at different settings. We also used fluorescent markers to check for smudging. In the mixed document tests we tested the prints against each other for clarity of text, merging colours, changing gradations of colours and white to black progressions. In our photo test, we printed an A4 size test photo, and checked the sharpness levels, colour output and also looked for flaws such as merging of colours or grain. For the mixed document and photo prints, we identified over five regions where printers usually struggle, and scored the outputs out of 10. The final quality score was an average of all the individual test scores. For the copy tests, we compared the output to the source and checked for noise, change in colour level, clarity, etc. Each test was timed, and that was also scored. Scanning speeds were also measured on all the MFDs. Features of MFDs often affect buying decisions, and

we gave considerable importance to this. We tested the ease with which cartridges could be replaced, ease of WiFi setup wherever applicable, how easy was the MFD to setup, and of course how user friendly was the software interface. We also felt that build quality of MFDs is important, and scored it accordingly. We did not really test the fax functionality, as some MFDs lacked it, and anyway, who uses fax any more?

As always, we also calculated the total cost of ownership (TCO). We did this to ensure that those MFDs which were priced low, but had high running costs weren't given any undue advantage. We assumed that the user will print at least 1000 prints for inkjet MFDs and 2000 prints for laser MFDs in a year and accordingly calculated the cost of ownership, taking into consideration the pricing of the cartridges and toners. The TCO index we got was considered in the overall score for the MFDs compared.

body. The input trays are a bit inconvenient as you will have to remove them completely to add or remove paper. Ink cartridges are inserted via a section on the extreme right hand side. We quite like the rubberised feel on the buttons and even the matte-black finish. Overall a decent build quality.

The Epson Office 960FWD comes in the traditional all black body. This colour inkjet multi-function device comes with a 2.5-inch LCD screen bang in the middle of the operational panel, which is neatly divided into four sections: Photo, Scan, Fax and Copy. The operational panel is tilt-able, making it easier to use while in a sitting or standing position.

The HP MFDs had some variety though. While the HP Deskjet 5525 was similar in aesthetics to the Brother MFDs, the Deskjet Ink Advantage 4615 was comparatively more bulky. The 5525 comes with a touch-screen control panel which is also a finger-print magnet. It

has a nice matte-black finish throughout and barring the memory card slot on the bottom left hand corner, there isn't much in terms of design on the MFD. The input tray seems flimsy and the scanner bed has fixed hinges which won't bode well for books of larger thicknesses. The Deskjet Ink Advantage 4615 comes in a brown body and had a backlit monochrome display on the control panel with dedicated buttons. Despite its chocolate brown colour, it looks quite pleasing to the eye. The automatic document feeder and the input tray is well built.

When it comes to monochrome laser MFDs, barring the Samsung SCX-3206W and Ricoh SP 100SF, most of the other MFDs had a larger scan bed area than the input trays at the base, thereby giving the MFDs a slightly triangular shape. The

Xerox Workcentre 3045 looks quite sturdy and has a neat, layered design with the input tray at the base having a dedicated opening for paper to come out and a scan bed at the top. The control panel on the 3045 is a backlit monochrome one with a four-way directional pad on the side. The Ricoh SP 1200S and Brother DCP7060D have similar designs, with the 1200S sporting an automatic document feeder. The displays on the 7060D and 1200S weren't backlit and because they were at a slight angle, you would

most likely have to stand up to operate them. The 7060D looks quite elegant though, thanks to a very nice, minimalistic design.

The Ricoh SP 100SF is the only MFD we tested that had its input tray on the back side and the front tray of the Samsung SCX-3206W is the largest in height as compared to the others. With a 7-segment LED on top and a minimal number of buttons, the SCX-3206W does not look as daunting at first sight as

the SP1200S. The Ricoh SP 100SF manages to keep its height lower despite sporting an ADF which opens up to hold the papers in the ADF tray. That is quite an achievement. Buttons on most of the monochrome MFDs are quite responsive, although the rubber ones on Brother 7060D need a long press to get a response at times.



Brother MFC-J625DW